

II. THE GUIDE

CHAPTER IV

MAIMONIDES AND THE THEOLOGIANS

BEFORE entering on a discussion of the main topics of the *Guide*, one preliminary point must be made. The *Guide* is intended for a special type of person. It is not addressed, for example (as so many modern books of the kind are), to the "ordinary reader": it presupposes knowledge, and demands study and thought. Nor again is it addressed (as might be expected) to the sceptic or *unbeliever*: the unbeliever has lost the very basis of faith and needs a different type of approach. It is addressed to the *believer*, but an intelligent believer who is disturbed and unsettled by the literal sense of the Scriptures and by the apologetics of the professional religionist. It is for this reason that the *Guide* opens with what looks like a Biblical dictionary and goes on to discuss the fallibility of theology. It is just the text of the Bible and the apologetics of the theologians which arouse doubt and perplexity in sincere minds.

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We may start from the former topic, the text of the Bible, and see how Maimonides proposes to resolve our perplexities.

He opens with a flank attack on the literal acceptance of the text of the Bible which is in effect what goes now by the name of fundamentalism. He does not waste words on its rebuttal. One cannot argue with a fundamentalist. All one can do is to show that there is a better way; and Maimonides does this by interpreting philosophically certain key Biblical terms. Matter and form; reason and imagination; true and false, and good and evil; degrees of knowledge and degrees of reality; essence and existence; teleology and the eternity of species; negation and privation; providence and chance; motion and rest; corporeality and spirit—all these and many other philosophical

distinctions are revealed in the words and phrases of the Scriptures. The allegorizing is thorough and systematic (though much wit has been vainly expended in trying to discover a reason for the precise order in which the terms are explained). "The Scriptures speak in human language," he quotes from the Talmud; that is to say (we are given to understand), the word of God contains all truth, but in order to bring truth down to earth it used the common vocabulary. In order, therefore, to recover truth we must get behind common vocabulary and see what it conceals.

The idea is of course not new. It has its analogue in Plato's use of Homer and Aristotle's treatment of myth, and it was developed fully in connection with Greek literature by the Stoics, and with the text of the Bible by the Alexandrian Jewish philosopher Philo. Many common-sense objections might be urged against it, and it may be deemed curious that the method in the hands of Philo, for example, revealed in the Scriptures the doctrine of Philo just as in the hands of Maimonides it revealed the doctrine of Maimonides. But all this is beside the point. Taken at their face value, certain statements of the Bible are unacceptable. They either contradict other statements or are objectionable in themselves and as such lead to "perplexity" and unbelief. There is only one way out, and that is, not to take them at their face value. In our day we incline to treat them as representing lower stages in history: Maimonides treated them as lower stages in expression. But the object is the same, to enable the religious man to draw the best from the Bible without deterrent. The historical view turns a blind eye on the "ragged edges," the Maimonidean turns an eye so sharp that it can see what was never there. But it has at least this to its credit, that it derives a maximum of edification from material which the historical view is committed to treat as unedifying; and the Bible is after all a book of edification.

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Closely connected with the allegorizing (or allegorizing away) of awkward passages from Scripture is Maimonides' treatment of Biblical miracle. As we shall see (below, p. 63),

his own world-view is so constructed as to admit (although not to demand) miracle, but at the same time he offers a key to those who were honestly puzzled by certain specific miracles recorded in Scripture. He points out (II, xli-xliv; cf. I, iv-v) that at least some miraculous events are mentioned as having taken place in dreams. It is possible to assume therefore that other miraculous events also took place in dreams, although this circumstance was not in these instances recorded. We may believe, e.g., that Ezekiel was ordered to consume the scroll, just as he was carried by the hair of his head from Babylon to Jerusalem, in a dream. Nor is there any deception in the account given in the Bible. It was assumed that in view of the numerous prophetic visions recorded elsewhere, we should understand that this too took place in a vision.

On the face of it this is not in some cases improbable; in others it is harder to believe, and it is difficult to understand why in the story of Balaam's ass, for example, such a material circumstance as that it all happened in a dream was allowed to pass unmentioned. But probable or no, Maimonides' method *offered a way out*. The way may not have been in accordance with our notions of the true function of exegesis (this was first enunciated by Spinoza in explicit criticism of these theories of Maimonides). It may have been ridden to absurdity—if not by Maimonides himself, then by his followers and the Maimonidean school in general. But in the light of the circumstances the allegorical and symbolical methods of interpretation proved then as ever a most powerful lever for the solution of intellectual perplexity. Perplexity arises in a thoughtful mind when it is bound irrevocably and irretrievably to the words of an ancient text. Allegory and symbolization preserve the allegiance while releasing the mind.¹

But the release is temporary only, and herein lies the real objection to the practice, if not of Maimonides himself then

¹ Renan's illuminating comment (*Averroes*, 3rd ed., p. 433) is still very much to the point: "Que serait devenue l'humanité, si, depuis dix-huit siècles, elle avait entendu la Bible avec les lexiques de Gesenius ou de Bretschneider? On ne crée rien avec un texte que l'on comprend trop exactement. L'interprétation vraiment féconde qui, dans l'autorité acceptée une fois pour toutes, sait trouver une réponse aux exigences sans cesse renaissantes de la nature humaine, est l'oeuvre de la conscience bien plus que de la philologie."

of the Maimonidean school. Maimonides tends to assume that the one truth is his truth; the allegory reveals just his point of view and no other. And so the method lapses into dogmatism, and a dogmatism which constrains the mind even more than does the original text of Scripture. The method of allegory is acceptable only when tempered by the principle of fluidity in interpretation.

Yet the root conception remains, and in Maimonides himself it is as a rule both fruitful and enlightening. The grosser anthropomorphisms of Scripture are at once purged away: the Paradise story is made significant as an account of evil; the ascent of Moses to God whose "face" could not be seen but whose "back" was made visible, patterns the ascent of humanity through the veils of ignorance, not to the grasping of the essence of God—God is in essence unknowable—but to an understanding of his "ways," that is, of his moral attributes which we are commanded to "cleave to" or imitate. It is with reference to this last that Maimonides remarks (I, xxi, 31-2)¹:

"You will surely not find it strange that this subject, so profound and difficult, should bear various interpretations; for it will not impair the force of the argument with which we are here concerned. Either explanation may be adopted; you may take that grand scene altogether as a prophetic vision, and the whole occurrence as a mental operation, and consider that what Moses sought, what was withheld from him, and what he attained, were things perceived by the intellect without the use of the senses (as we have explained above): or you may assume that in addition there was a certain ocular perception of a material object, the sight of which would assist intellectual perception . . . You may also assume that in addition there was a perception of sound, and that there was a voice which passed before him, and was undoubtedly something material. You may choose either of these opinions, for our sole intention and purpose is to guard you against the belief that the phrase 'and the Lord passed,' is analogous to 'pass

¹ All references to the text of the *Guide* are to the one-volume edition of the English translation of M. Friedlaender (Routledge, 1904; many later reprints). The large Roman numerals represent the book, the small Roman numerals the chapter, and the ordinary numerals the pages.

before the people,' for God, being incorporeal, cannot be said to move, and consequently the verb 'to pass' cannot with propriety be applied to Him in its primary signification."

Thus, in conception at least, Maimonides offers freedom. He has given the key and made suggestions as to its use. It is for his reader to fit it to his perplexities.

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The first position has now been gained. We have in our hands a positive principle to help us with the primary textbook of religion, and the point has been established that it is not the words which determine the religion; it is the religion which determines the meaning of the words. The argument now arises to a higher level, marked by an interlude and certain appropriate digressions¹, and proceeds to examine the nature of the central object of religion revealed (or concealed) in the words of the Bible.

We dismiss at once the human pictures the Bible gives of God. God is not man, and when God is spoken of as man it is only in order to impress on us the fact of his existence in a way which the ordinary man cannot mistake. But just as God is not man, so he is not, as often thought, an amalgam of such qualities as life, power, wisdom and will. He is not indeed, properly speaking, alive, powerful, wise or willing, or even (in the ordinary sense of the word) existing. To say the former is to make him four, not one; to say the latter is to attribute to him qualities which in him have no meaning. Man is said to be alive because man can die; he is said to be wise because he can also be foolish; he is said to exist because he can be conceived as non-existing. But God is what he is eternally, from everlasting to everlasting, and he is irrevocably and essentially one. The perplexed therefore need not be puzzled how the unity of God can be united with the variety of his attributes. The attributes are not real; they are distinguishable only

¹ I must repeat that I am not giving an analysis of the *Guide*, the detailed structure of which has given occasion for much careful study, but only endeavouring to seize some of its main positions.

logically, not factually; they exist only in the thoughts of man. They are pictorial expressions used in order to enable man to understand something, and express something, of the divine essence. But they must not be taken literally. The proposition: "God is wise" means only that he is not what in man we call foolish: "God is living" means only that he is not what in man we call dead. These propositions are positive only in their grammatical form. In reality, they are negative. We grow in our real knowledge of God not as we add to them but as we learn to negate them, and the more we negate the more we know.

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We seem to be approaching the position adumbrated in the well-known phrase: *Deus non immerito nihil esse videtur*, and indeed the doctrine of "negative theology" and of the "negative way" is familiar enough in the history of thought. By itself it is apt to lead to a barren agnosticism. But it will be remembered that so far as the *Guide* is concerned we are only at the beginning of our enquiry and are speaking within the orbit of an historic religion. We are trying to resolve the perplexities of the *believer*, and Maimonides is anxious from the first to free him from the embarrassment of the logical puzzle of the relationship between "the one" and "the many" in God, and to lay down the basis for a purified monotheism. He sees that the root error is anthropomorphism, the describing of God in terms which have relevance only to man. His first task is therefore to clear God of all relation to the transitory or the merely human. God is the absolute existent, and is thus different in kind from the contingent and possible existents which constitute the world of our experience and are caught up in our vocabulary. The plain man's view of God, howbeit honest, is a pictorial misrepresentation, and we must strip ourselves of it before we can rise to a more adequate grasp.

Yet even at this stage, Maimonides has something illuminating to say of a positive character. God's essence may be unknowable. Even existence may be attributable to him only in human fashion and with due allowance for the frailties of

language. But he is known through his works. He is revealed—not wholly, but (however partially, perhaps infinitesimally) certainly—in the created world. The perplexed therefore should rise above the verbal difficulties of their texts and penetrate into the science of nature. In nature they will find the works of God, and through those works God himself.

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And God is knowable not only through his works. He is revealed also through his working. It is remarkable that it is just in these “agnostic” chapters of the “negative way,” leavened though they may be by the introductory insistence on the necessity to study the natural sciences (I, xxxiv), that Maimonides dilates on the view which is hinted at, as we saw, in the very opening chapters of the *Guide*, the view, namely, that the moral attributes of God are the ways we are commanded as men to follow:

“The wisest man, our Teacher Moses, asked two things of God, and received a reply respecting both. The one thing he asked was, that God should let him know His true essence; the other, which in fact he asked first, that God should let him know His attributes. In answer to both these petitions God promised that He would let him know all His attributes, and that these were nothing but His actions. He also told him that His true essence could not be perceived, and pointed out a method by which he could obtain the utmost knowledge of God possible for man to acquire.”

After a brief digression he resumes:

“Moses prayed to God to grant him knowledge of His attributes, and he continued to pray for the knowledge of God’s essence in the words, ‘Show me thy glory,’ and then received respecting his first request (‘Show me thy way’) the following favourable reply: ‘I shall make all my goodness to pass before thee’; as regards the second request, however, he was told: ‘thou canst not see my face.’ The words ‘all my

goodness' imply that God promised to show him the whole creation, concerning which it has been stated: 'And God saw everything that he had made, and, behold, it was very good' (Gen. i, 31). When I say 'to show him the whole creation,' I mean to imply that God promised to make him comprehend the nature of all things, their relation to each other, and the way they are governed by God both in reference to the universe as a whole and to each creature in particular. This knowledge is referred to when we are told of Moses, 'he is firmly established in all mine house' (Num. xii, 7); that is, 'his knowledge of all the creatures in My universe is correct and firmly established,' for false opinions are not firmly established. Consequently the knowledge of the works of God is the knowledge of His attributes, by which He can be known. The fact that God promised Moses to give him a knowledge of His works, may be inferred from the circumstance that God taught him such attributes as refer exclusively to His works, viz., 'merciful and gracious, long-suffering and abundant in goodness' etc. (Exod. xxxiv, 6).

"It is therefore clear that the ways which Moses wished to know, and which God taught him, are the actions emanating from God. Our Sages call them *middoth* (qualities), and speak of the thirteen *middoth* of God; they used the term also in reference to man, compare the sayings: 'there are four different *middoth* (characters) among those who go to the house of learning'; 'there are four different *middoth* (characters) among those who give charity.' They do not mean to say that God really possesses *middoth* (qualities), but that He performs actions similar to such of our actions as originate in certain qualities, i.e., in certain psychical dispositions; not that God has really such dispositions. Although Moses was shown 'all His goodness,' i.e., all His works, only the thirteen *middoth* are mentioned, because they include those acts of God which refer to the creation and the government of mankind, and to know these acts was the principal object of the prayer of Moses. This is shown by the conclusion of his prayer: 'that I may know thee, that I may find grace in thy sight, and consider that this nation is thy people' (Exod. xxxiii, 16), that is to say, the people whom I have to rule by certain acts in the

performance of which I must be guided by Thy own acts in governing them." (I, liv)

We have then the three points—God in his essence cannot be known; all that we can know of him is through his acts; his acts are to be seen both in his visible handiwork, the created world, which it is our duty to study, and in his moral activity which it behoves us to imitate. Maimonides concludes the discussion thus:

"We have shown why it has been considered sufficient to mention only these (thirteen) out of all His acts; namely, because they are required for the good government of a country; for the chief aim of man should be to make himself, as far as possible, similar to God: that is to say, to make his acts similar to the acts of God, or as our Sages expressed it in explaining the verse, 'Ye shall be holy' (Lev. xix, 2): 'He is gracious, so be you also gracious; He is merciful, so be you also merciful.' "

The final summary reverts to the main point:

"The principal object of this chapter was to show that all attributes ascribed to God are attributes of His acts, and do not imply that God has any qualities."

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Fundamentalism offends through its undue familiarity with God. Maimonides' theology seems so far to err in the other direction. He quotes a story from the Talmud to the effect that a man leading the congregation in prayer in the presence of Rabbi Hannaniah started adding a string of honorific epithets to the name of God, and was only stopped by the Rabbi interrupting him and asking: "Have you finished all the praises of your Maker?" The point is obvious. Reverence demands reticence. In the words of the Psalmist: "Before thee praise is silent."

But Maimonides goes further. It is not only that we should not pile up unnecessarily the attributes of God. The attributes "of God" are not *his* attributes at all. As we have seen, they are only modes of describing his activities and do not touch his essence which is by its very nature unknowable. Theology therefore can never attain to a knowledge of its object and as a science can do no more than negate false views. It is true that Maimonides tells us that although God in his essence is unknowable his works are there for all to behold, and that therefore, if we wish to know something of him, we should study physics and astronomy. But this would seem to imply that in escaping from theological agnosticism we have fallen into scientific positivism.

We shall see later that Maimonides was no more a positivist than he was an agnostic. It is important however to grasp the sincerity of his appeal to a knowledge of the facts of the physical world. There he found a sure basis, the only sure basis, for mature belief.

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This comes out clearly in the third great topic of the first book of the *Guide*, the examination of the theologians. The theologians thought otherwise. For them the world is a chaos, and for that very reason needed a guiding hand. Indeed it was only on the assumption that the world is a chaos that they thought the existence of a guiding hand could be proved. If the world as it really is, is a swirl of atoms, coming no-whence, leading no-whither, then every instance of order or law or even sequence which should present itself would be a proof that God had intervened and produced it; if not for God's intervention, primitive chaos would reign even now. Thus for the theologians there is *ab initio* no science or even possibility of science. Science means the discovery of law in the structure or the behaviour of things. But if the merest sequence is due to the direct intervention of the deity, there is no law in nature to discover.

We have here the direct opposite of Maimonidism. For Maimonides the world is an ordered whole and we proceed

from nature to nature's God. For the theologians there is no such thing as nature; if there were, God would not exist. Fundamentally, theirs is the *sceptical* argument for the existence of God. In themselves (the argument would appear to premise), things are not connected with one another: each thing is an atomic unit separate from all others. But we see them connected. There must exist therefore a supreme power to connect them. Or we may put it another way: because we know nothing, whatever knowledge we have must be divine; and we know nothing because there is nothing to know.

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The chapter in which Maimonides explains the position of the theologians is historically one of the most interesting in the literature of medieval philosophy, and that because there is contained in it a striking expression of a famous theory connected in modern thought most generally with the name of Hume, but familiar to students of Descartes and Pascal as well. Whether it is a fair or complete description of the actual views of the school Maimonides is combating is a question which does not concern us here. The treatment is so vivid however that it is difficult to believe that it does not refer literally to some actual thinker or school, and to a doctrine generally accepted. Maimonides describes the logical consequence of the atomic theory of things in the form adopted by the theologians of the day. If atoms are really atoms, they are entirely distinct and apart from one another; they cannot cohere into wholes. They cannot act upon one another, either individually or in groups; they cannot be held in the bonds of a unitary time or of a unitary space; they cannot stand to one another in the relation of cause and effect. Motion and velocity, succession, continuity and coherence of any kind—all lose their meaning. The atoms remain atoms, each one self-imprisoned, self-sufficient, self-supporting, self-contained.

There is thus no permanence and no regularity. Time itself is an aggregate of time atoms. The world is renewed

every moment, or it could not continue to exist. A hand writes with a pen and the paper is covered with characters? Nay! neither hand nor pen is a substantive entity with fixed qualities and powers; nor indeed is the paper or even the characters inscribed on it. It is God and God alone who joins the hand of one moment of time to the hand of what we call the next moment of time, and makes them into what we call one hand. His and his alone is the sustaining power by which pen and paper of one moment are one with the pen and paper of the next; his and his alone by which the action of the hand and the ink produce what appear in the end as the written characters, his and his alone by which our will and knowledge remain one and ours. God is all in all, and here is the proof: without him there would be nothing, neither human will nor hand nor pen nor paper nor writing.

The theory is so remarkable that one cannot refrain from quotation:

"The cloth which according to our belief we dyed red, has not been dyed by us at all, but God created that colour in the cloth when it came into contact with the red pigment; we believe that colour to have penetrated into the cloth, but they assert that this is not the case. They say that God generally acts in such a way, that, e.g., the black colour is not created unless the cloth is brought into contact with indigo; but this blackness, which God creates in the instant when the cloth touches the black pigment, is of no duration, and another creation of blackness then takes place; they further say that after the blackness is gone, He does not create a red or green colour, but again a black colour.

"According to this principle, the knowledge which we have of certain things to-day, is not the same which we had of them yesterday; that knowledge is gone, and another like it has been created. They positively believe that this does take place, knowledge being an accident. In like manner it would follow that the soul, according to those who believe that it is an accident, is renewed each moment in every animated being, say a hundred thousand times; for, as you know, time is composed of time-atoms. In accordance with this principle

they assert that when man is perceived to move a pen, it is not he who has really moved it; the motion produced in the pen is an accident which God has created in the pen; the apparent motion of the hand which moves the pen is likewise an accident which God has created in the moving hand; but the creative act of God is performed in such a manner that the motion of the hand and the motion of the pen follow each other closely; but the hand does not act, and is not the cause of the pen's motion; for, as they say, an accident cannot pass from one thing to another. Some of them accordingly contend that this white cloth, which is coloured when put into the vessel filled with indigo, has not been blackened by the indigo; for blackness being an attribute of indigo, does not pass from one object to another. There does not exist anything to which an action could be ascribed; the real agent is God." (I, lxxiii, 125)

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The discussion of the current theology (I, lxxiii-vi) is prefaced by a striking chapter (lxxii; cf. below, pp. 91) on the unity of the universe. In it Maimonides affirms his scientific faith. It is a belief in a world not of quality-less impermanent atoms but of interdependent parts endowed with permanent properties and organized in permanent kinds; it is a belief in the coherence of structure and regularity of behaviour which we call law. Maimonides' world is a world of law, law open to enquiry and ascertainable by investigation. The fact that he regarded the universe, Greek-fashion¹, as animate and endowed with soul, is only a forceful way of emphasizing this conception. The universe is one in the sense that a living body is one, and the very variety of its interlocking parts is that which constitutes its unity. From the one so described Maimonides feels he can argue fairly to the One as its author, and he fulminates with unusual vehemence against the theologians who, by denying

¹ On the whole subject reference should be made to R. G. Collingwood, *Idea of Nature* (Oxford, 1945; e.g., p. 111), and the masterly volumes of Pierre Duhem, *Le système du monde, histoire des doctrines cosmologiques de Platon à Copernic*, Paris, 1913.

the existence of a fixed structure to the world, destroy the ground of rational belief.

But the theologians are not the real source of perplexity. They fly so obviously in the face both of experience and of reason that they can be easily refuted. The scientists are of sterner stuff, and Maimonides turns to them.